

Data Entry

Entering numbers, text and dates correctly

7

Topics

7

Practices

3

Data types

1

Class Results sheet

The three types of data

3.1 • Theory

Text

Words, names, headings — not a number

Student Name

ALIGNS LEFT

e.g. Karachi, January

Numbers

Pure numbers used for calculations

1000

ALIGNS RIGHT

e.g. 85, 3.14, -50

Dates & Times

Recognised date or time formats

05/04/2026

ALIGNS RIGHT

e.g. 14:30, April 5

WATCH OUT

Number left-aligned? Excel treats it as text — it will NOT calculate with it.

Practice 3.1: Sheet headers

Practice · 1 of 7

GOAL

Create the column headings for your Class Results sheet.

1 Click **A1**. Type **Student Name** → Tab.

2 Type **Score** → Tab.

3 Type **Percentage** → Tab.

4 Type **Phone** → Tab.

5 Type **Date Joined** → Enter.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- All five headers align LEFT
- Left = Excel sees them as Text

Entering data

3.2 · Theory

Click the cell → type → confirm. Your data appears in the cell and in the Formula Bar.

Enter

Confirm and move DOWN one cell

Tab

Confirm and move RIGHT one cell

Shift + Tab

Confirm and move LEFT one cell

Arrow Keys

Confirm and move in that direction

Esc

Cancel — discard what you typed, keep the original

F2

Enter edit mode on an existing cell

TIP

Use Tab to move right when filling a row — then press Enter at the end to jump to the start of the next row.

Practice 3.2: Keyboard entry

Practice · 2 of 7

GOAL

Fill three rows using Tab and Enter only.

- 1 Click **A2**. Type **Ahmed Ali** → Tab.
- 2 Type **85** → Tab. Type **85%** → Tab.
- 3 Press Tab to skip Phone. Type **5/4/2026** → Enter.
- 4 Row 3: **Sara Khan, 92, 92%**, skip, **12/4/2026**.
- 5 Row 4: **Bilal Raza, 78, 78%**, skip, **19/4/2026**.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- Names align LEFT
- Numbers, % and dates align RIGHT

Entering text

3.3 · Theory

1

Text too long for column

PROBLEM

Text spills into the next column if it is empty, or gets cut off if the next column has data.

FIX

Widen the column by dragging its border — or double-click the border to auto-fit.

2

Number as text (phones, IDs)

PROBLEM

Typing **001234** — Excel removes the leading zero and stores the number 1234.

FIX

Type an apostrophe first: **'001234** — Excel then treats the entry as text.

3

Text wrapping inside a cell

PROBLEM

Long text spills into adjacent cells and can be hard to read.

FIX

Home tab → Alignment group → **Wrap Text** — text wraps onto multiple lines inside the cell.

Practice 3.3: Phone numbers

Practice · 3 of 7

GOAL

Keep the leading zero in phone numbers.

- 1 Click **D2**. Type **03001234567** → Enter.
- 2 The zero disappeared! Click **D2** → press Delete.
- 3 Type **' 03001234567** (apostrophe first) → Enter.
- 4 **D3**: type **' 03009876543** → Enter.
- 5 **D4**: type **' 03451122334** → Enter.
- 6 Double-click the border of the column D header.

YOU SHOULD SEE

03001234567 → 3001234567

'03001234567 → 03001234567

- Text aligns LEFT — the zero stays

Entering numbers

3.4 • Theory

Whole number	Just type the number	150
Decimal	Use a dot (.) not a comma (,)	3.75
Negative	Type a minus sign before the number	-50
Percentage	Type the number then % (stored as 0.85)	85%
Fraction	Type 0, a space, then the fraction — not 3/4!	0 3/4
Large number	Type without commas — format later	1000000
Currency	Type the number only — add Rs. with a format later	5000

WATCH OUT

Never type 3/4 directly — Excel reads it as March 4th (a date). Always use 0 3/4.

Practice 3.4: Fractions

Practice · 4 of 7

GOAL

Add Attendance with fractions — without making dates.

1 Click **F1**. Type **Attendance** → Enter.

2 **F2**: type 0 3/4 → Enter.

3 **F3**: type 1 → Enter.

4 **F4**: type 0 1/2 → Enter.

5 Click **C2**. Look at the Formula Bar.

YOU SHOULD SEE

0 3/4 → 3/4

0 1/2 → 1/2

● C2 shows 85% but stores 0.85

Entering dates and times

What you type	What Excel recognises
5/4/2026	5 April 2026 (day / month / year)
04-05-2026	5 April 2026 (day - month - year)
5 Apr 2026	5 April 2026 (short month name)
April 5	5 April — current year assumed
14:30	2:30 PM (24-hour format)
2:30 PM	2:30 PM (12-hour format)

Dates are stored as numbers

1 Jan 1900 = 1

1 Jan 2000 = 36,526

5 Apr 2026 = 46,117

This is why date arithmetic works — e.g. finding the days between two dates.

Practice 3.5: Date arithmetic

Practice · 5 of 7

GOAL

Count how many days each student has been enrolled.

1 Click **G1**. Type **Days Enrolled** → Enter.

2 **G2**: type **=TODAY () -E2** → Enter.

3 Click **G2**. Drag the fill handle down to **G4**.

4 If you see dates: select **G2 : G4** → Home → Number Format → **Number**.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- Whole numbers in G2:G4
- Dates are stored as numbers, so we can subtract them

Editing cell content

3.6 • Theory

Replace content

Click the cell → type new data → Enter. The old content is overwritten.

Edit part of it

Double-click the cell (or press F2). Edit → Enter.

Delete content only

Click the cell → press Delete. Formatting stays.

Delete content and formatting

Select cells → Home → Editing → Clear → Clear All.

Undo a mistake

Ctrl + Z — works just like in Word. Press it several times to undo several steps.

TIP

Delete only removes data. Background colour and borders stay — use Clear All to remove everything.

Practice 3.6: Edit and correct

Practice · 6 of 7

GOAL

Replace, edit, delete and undo.

1 Click **B2**. Type **88** → Enter.

2 Double-click **A3**. Click after Sara and type **h** → Enter.

3 Click **C4**. Press **Delete**.

4 Press **Ctrl+Z** to bring it back.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- B2 shows 88
- A3 shows Sarah Khan
- C4 is back after Undo

Useful data entry tricks

3.7 · Theory

Ctrl + Enter

Fill many cells at once

Select all the target cells first → type your data once → press Ctrl + Enter instead of Enter.

Saves time when entering the same value in many cells.

Enter

AutoComplete

As you type, Excel suggests words from earlier entries in the same column. Press Enter to accept, or keep typing to ignore it.

Works for text only — not numbers or dates.

Alt + ↓

Drop-down from column

Press Alt + ↓ in any cell to see a list of all unique values already typed above. Click to select.

Keeps data consistent — no spelling variations.

Practice 3.7: Speed tricks

Practice · 7 of 7

GOAL

Fill a Status column quickly.

- 1 Click **H1**. Type **Status** → Enter.
- 2 Select **H2 : H4**.
- 3 Type **Present** → press **Ctrl+Enter**.
- 4 Click **H5**. Type **Pr** → Enter to accept.
- 5 Click **H6**. Press **Alt+↓** → pick Present.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- H2:H4 all say Present
- H5 and H6 say Present
- Your Class Results sheet is complete!

Unit 3 — Key takeaways

3.1 Text aligns left — Numbers and Dates align right. Left-aligned numbers mean a problem.

3.2 Enter confirms down, Tab confirms right, Esc cancels, F2 opens edit mode.

3.3 Use an apostrophe (') to force a number to be stored as text.

3.4 Use a dot for decimals (3.75), type 0 3/4 for fractions, no commas in large numbers.

3.5 Dates are stored as numbers internally — this enables date arithmetic.

3.6 Delete clears content only. Use Clear All to remove content and formatting.

3.7 Ctrl+Enter fills many cells. AutoComplete and Alt+↓ speed up repeated entry.

Your completed Class Results sheet

Result

Built step by step in Practices 1–7 — every skill from Unit 3 in one sheet.

Student Name	Score	%	Phone	Date	Att.	Days	Status
Ahmed Ali	88	88%	03001234567	05/04/2026	3/4	24	Present
Sarah Khan	92	92%	03009876543	12/04/2026	1	17	Present
Bilal Raza	78	78%	03451122334	19/04/2026	1/2	10	Present

CHECK YOUR WORK

Text left, numbers and dates right, phone numbers keep their zeros, fractions show as fractions.